Taking Over

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Taking Over

by dead_frog

Summary

"Weaver!" Adora screamed over the comms, desperate to get some kind of response, "Sergeant Weaver! Do you copy?!" She paused, hand shaking violently as she clutched onto her radio. She looked at the burning building in flames right in front of her. Tears welled in her eyes and a deep pit of anxiety brewed in her stomach at the lack of response, "Fuck! Catra, baby, *please*!"

"I'm here," Catra choked out, her voice *just* not overshadowed by the crushing sounds of the building collapsing with her still inside, "I'm alive."

-

Captain Adora Grey of the Brightmoon Police Department (BMPD) and her ex-wife Sergeant Catra Weaver respond to an active shooter scene at their local mall.

Notes

watched the b99 ep where rosa responds to an active shooter ep and it made me write this so enjoy

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Adora- Now

"Active shooter, potential hostage situation in Mystacore Mall. Requesting additional backup," Adora's eyes widened and she nervously reached for her radio. It was midnight- the mall was just about to close and the shops inside were probably shut.

"Herman, 3764. Show me going," This was the standard procedure- listing their last name and badge number and stating 'show me going' to announce that they were responding to the scene.

"3764, I have you going," The Officer on the other line responded.

"Perez, 1848. Show me going,"

"1848, I have you going,"

"Weaver, 6766. Show me going," Adora's heart stopped. That was Catra's last name and her badge number. Catra was responding to the scene. Regardless of the fact that Catra was Adora's ex-wife, Adora instantly began worrying about Catra.

"6766, I have you going,"

"Grey, 4723. Show me going," Adora called in as she got in her car.

"4723, I have you going," With the approval to respond to the scene, Adora flicked on her lights and sirens and began speeding to Mystacore Mall.

"Captain Grey," Bow greeted Adora upon arriving.

"Can I get a status update?" Adora requested as she eyed the front of Mystacore Mall. Stolen cars were smashed into the entrance, barricading it off.

"Officer Hawk and Officer D'ream are currently stuck inside with potentially three active shooters and an unknown number of accomplices. Unknown number of civilians, one of which is being held hostage. Sergeant Weaver is going in-"

"Where is she?!" Adora asked in a panic. Bow stuttered and pointed towards where Catra was situating her bulletproof vest. "You're going in?!" Adora shouted as she ran to Catra.

"I'm the most experienced active field officer we have here *and* I'm a Sergeant," Catra scowled back, putting in an ear wire connected to the radio. Adora paused, taken aback at Catra's assertiveness, "I'm going in,"

"Yeah," Adora affirmed. Catra rolled her eyes and walked away, holding her radio to her face.

"This is Sergeant Weaver testing the radio. I'm going in,"

"Wait! Weaver!" Adora called out. Catra turned around and frowned. Adora ran up to her and put her hands on Catra's shoulders, "just… stay safe," Catra's frown eased and her eyes went soft- something Adora hadn't seen from her in ages.

"Always am, Grey," She smiled, somewhat nervously, then approached the building. She went behind the back, likely to enter covertly. Adora watched until Catra went out of sight and then walked back to Bow.

"We need to barricade the street and get every exit covered by officers. Keep the main radio line clear for the Officers inside. Call in any reinforcements we can," Adora instructed, "I'm taking over."

<u>Catra - Now</u>

Catra finally entered the building after carefully weaving her way in through an external vent because every entrance was barricaded off. Her heart was racing, but it was all part of the job.

This was what she was trained to do, it was what she was best at. She was strong, agile, quiet but quick and risky yet cautious.

"This is Captain Grey. I'm the head of this situation. Report any updates to me and ensure to follow instructions," Adora's voice announced on the radio. Catra resisted the urge to scoff, because of *course* her ex-wife decided to take over the scene. Still, Catra wasn't an idiot. She needed someone clear-minded and focused in her ear and she *knew* Adora was the right person for the job.

All her senses were alert, every tiny sound on overdrive. Her ears swivelled, listening to all the movements on every floor. *Two, maybe three people on her floor. Not good*. She listened to the shuffles, then a loud scream. Catra sprung to action.

"Please- please no!" The voice screamed. Catra sprinted, pulling her gun out from the holster and raising it. She found two shooters quickly. She watched only for a moment as they raised their guns at a frantic woman. Catra couldn't shoot yet. Her elbow landed right in one of them, her leg kicking the other. Catra's ears flattened and her eyes scrunched shut for a split second as loud bangs echoed. *Shots fired. None landed*. Catra didn't stop though and she managed to knock one out with a whack of her gun. The frantic woman had long run off the moment Catra had distracted them. Catra heard a shuffle nearby and her head flickered to see who it was when she got shoved to the ground onto her back.

"Don't fucking move!" He yelled. Catra's head shifted and her eyes met a handgun. She studied it carefully, "throw your gun away!" Catra's eyes didn't even widen.

"You didn't take off the safety, genius," Catra scoffed, snatching the gun and kicking him in the gut from the floor. He hunched over in pain and in the moment of weakness, Catra quickly got up, grabbed him by his hair and yanked him into a chokehold. He scrabbled at her arm but Catra didn't relent until he went limp. Catra dropped him to the ground and panted breathlessly, her eyes shaking as she looked at the two men on the ground. *Not dead, just unconscious*. She tried to reassure herself. Her hand

snaked to her earpiece, “Weaver 6766,” She said on the radio, “two shooters down, unconscious on ground floor by the food court.” She disclosed over the radio in a hushed voice, “shots fired, none landed out,”

“10-4 affirmative,” Adora responded. Catra let out a relieved sigh at hearing her voice, trying not to let tears well in her eyes. “How are you doing, Sarge?”

“I got shoved, apart from that I’m fine. Yet to locate Hawk or D’ream, but it’s a five story building so I don’t expect-... 10-6,” Catra stopped talking when she heard someone move. Her eyes flicked towards the sound. *A little girl and boy. Barely 10*. “Hey, come here,” Catra gestured, opening her arms, “I’ll get you guys out.” They both approached fearfully. Catra’s hand went back to her radio earpiece, “found two kids, is there an exit unsupervised,”

“We’re unsure about the back exit on the ground floor. The glass is covered. I advise you to navigate the children to the vent if possible. We have Officers waiting for civilians,” Adora counselled. Catra hummed an affirmative.

“Copy that. I’ll check out the back exit after,” Catra led the children to the vent, helping them in, “just go straight ahead,” She instructed. The children didn’t even speak, just quickly shuffling ahead in the vent, “why aren’t you sending backup?” Catra muttered as she walked away.

“SWAT is arriving in ten minutes… um… the vent is too small for any of our other Officers here,” Adora admitted. Catra frowned.

“What, are you calling me small?” Catra frowned. No way was the vent *that* small. Yeah it was a little cushy… and her shoulders were squeezed against each wall… but-

“You’re 5’1. Everyone else is over 5’6,” Adora said. Catra went to respond when she remembered the radio wasn’t just a personal call with Adora.

"Copy that. Over," Catra scoffed. She navigated her way to the back exit when she heard a gentle ticking. *Tick. Tick. Tick.* Catra's heart dropped out of her chest when she recognised what it was. She snuck towards the door to get a visual- a look that confirmed her thoughts, "Hold off on SWAT! The door is rigged with a bomb!" She whisper-yelled over the radio, "10-3, disconnecting for a moment," Catra instructed, pulling the earpiece out. She closed her eyes- even if it made her vulnerable- and focussed on her hearing. *Tick. Tick. Tick, Ţi̊c̊k̊. Ţi̊c̊k̊.* It echoed, overlapped. *Too many sounds for just one bomb*. She put the earpiece back in,

"-egeant Weaver! Do you copy?!" Adora's voice was serious and loud, undoubtedly mad at Catra for disconnecting.

"The whole fucking building is a ticking bomb," Catra rushed out, her face mortified, "it's all- everything is- *fuck*," Catra stumbled through her words, "clear the block and-"

"Weaver, breathe," Adora instructed sternly, "you're one of three officers in there, have you seen anyone else?"

"Apart from the kids and two shooters? No," Catra confirmed, "don't tell me to leave. I'm not letting innocent people die in here without trying,"

"You're not equipped to handle this," Adora rebutted.

"I don't fucking care! Help me navigate this or I'll do it on my own," Catra threatened.

<u>Adora - Now</u>

Adora's heart raced, stuck in a sticky position, "Alright Weaver," Adora relented, knowing how stubborn Catra was. "Work fast on scanning the floors. Are the shops open?" The line was silent for a quick pause, yet every quick pause left Adora terrified of the worst.

"No," Catra responded, "they're all closed. That's good right?" Catra asked. Adora heard the slightest tremble in Catra's voice. *No*

one else would be able to hear that.

"Yeah, less area to scan," Adora confirmed, "you're doing well. Just keep the comms connected at *all times*," Adora asserted sternly. She heard Catra hum affirmatively on the other side.

"Copy that, Grey. Scanning over the ground floor. Over," and then- Adora was left to deal with silence. Nothing in her whole career had been harder than this. She was out of control- unable to help manage the situation, isolated from the scene and forced to watch from the outside- or more so listen from the gunshots and Catra's updates. Bow approached Adora and put his hand on her shoulder. Adora jumped.

"Sorry Captain," Bow apologised. "The immediate perimeter has been evacuated. SWAT have surrounded the mall's perimeter and will enter the back entrance on your call,"

"Good," Adora responded, biting on the inside of her lip.

"You need to get into a bomb suit," Bow handed her one. He was already dressed in one. Adora didn't want to leave the radio unassisted for even a moment. Bow narrowed his eyes at Adora's hesitation.

"Stay posted on the radio." Adora instructed immediately beginning to get into it. In the middle of getting into the hefty suit, Catra's voice cracked on the radio.

"Captain Grey, come in," Catra whispered in a hushed voice. Adora immediately abandoned trying to put on her suit and grabbed the radio.

"10-4, Weaver, this is Captain Grey," Adora responded.

"I can hear Chief Glimmer. She's stuck in the building."

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

ruhroh

Catra - Three Years Ago

Catra didn't like Glimmer. She was rude and a dick and no matter how much Adora tried to explain her actions away, she just *couldn't*. Because Glimmer was a dick. Catra kept it to herself, at least most of the time. She'd always give the occasional tease. Adora left for the grocery shop just five minutes ago, promising she'd be back in time for when Glimmer came over. By the sound of the knock on the door, Adora was *not* home in time. Catra let out a soft groan, walking towards the door, "Hey Sparkles," Catra smirked, her tail swaying behind her.

"You *know* it's Glimmer," She scowled back, pushing past Catra, "where's Adora?"

"She just went out to get the groceries," Catra said, walking to the couch and sitting down.

"Can't do anything for her, can you?" Glimmer jabbed. Catra's eyes flickered up from her phone, confused at where the verbal assault was coming from.

"Excuse me?" Catra spat, "what're you talking about?"

"She's always picking up your slack around here, keeping everything together. I'm surprised you two are still married," Glimmer critiqued. Catra's heart was racing.

"She married me because she loves me," Catra hissed.

"You got married when you were 20. Hardly seems smart,"

"We've known each other for our whole lives!"

“And *that's* the reason she’s with you,” Glimmer pointed out, “she never got to experiment and find out what she really likes,”

“What the fuck is wrong with you?”

“I’m just tired of seeing my best friend stuck in a relationship with you.”

“Just shut up!” Catra screamed. Her eyes welled up with tears, “I don’t know if you-you’re jealous or you thought I deserved this but get the fuck out of mine and Adora’s home,”

“Hm,” Glimmer hummed, “can’t take criticism?”

“I’m not gonna let you talk down to me as though you're a part of my relationship. ‘Cause you're *not.* So fucking leave.”

Later, Adora arrived home. For someone who was just getting groceries, she sure took way longer, “I’m home,” Adora announced, but there’s no light in her voice. Catra ran up to Adora and hugged her

“Adora, baby, I-” Catra paused when Adora didn't hug back.

“You fought with Glimmer again?” Adora’s voice was low, “I thought you were gonna go easy on her,”

“Wait *what*?!” Catra hissed, pushing Adora away, “I was! She was the one that started attacking me,” Catra defended herself, “she started saying all this shit about how I don’t put in enough effort and that-”

“Catra, please, I don’t have time for this,” Adora walked off, putting the grocery bags on the counter.

“What?” Catra said quietly.

“Glimmer was just talking to me and she said that you were being a dick and not letting her inside,”

“What?! She’s lying!” Catra pointed out. Adora frowned.

“Well I don’t know who to believe,” Adora crossed her arms. Catra’s eyebrows furrowed, “she was really upset, Catra, and she said she was trying to be nice-” One thing was evident to Catra- Adora didn’t trust her word.

“Are you kidding,” Catra cut Adora off. Tears welled in her eyes. Adora paused her train of thought, noticing how Catra’s pupils had shrunk to pin pricks and her body was shaking. She held her arms eyes watering, “I’m fucking leaving,” she pushed past Adora and went straight to their room.

“Cat, wait-” Adora started, quickly following Catra.

“Fuck no,” Catra hissed, lugging a suitcase down from the top of the wardrobe, “y’know Glimmer was saying that you never got to ‘experiment’ and ‘find who you really like’ because you’re stuck with me. Why don't you go and do that and find someone better, because you clearly don’t want me,”

“What?! Don’t- wait, just stop!” Adora panicked as Catra packed stuff away, “I do want you, I just-”

“No, Adora! You just want to hold onto our relationship that we clearly don’t have!”

“It’s not like that!” Adora denied, “I just don’t like being stuck in the middle of my wife and my best friend. It’s hard!”

Catra let out a dry laugh, borderline delirious, “Well it’s hard having my own wife not even listen to my side!” Catra scowled, “you *clearly* don’t trust me so I’m leaving,” She zipped up the bag and left before Adora could even stop her.

<u>Catra - Now</u>

Adora didn’t respond for a good minute, leaving Catra to a gaping silence, “10-3, disconnecting,” Catra took her earpiece out and focussed, listening to Glimmer’s shrill voice. Barely able to hear,

she once again focused deeply on her hearing. *'They know I'm here! I'm the Chief, so they'll come soon!'* Catra sighed- Glimmer had given herself up like a bargaining chip. Catra was sure that she was lying to the shooters taking her hostage, because *no one* was aware that Glimmer was in the building, She quickly slid the earpiece back in, "10-8, I'm reconnected,"

"Sergeant Weaver, do *not* disconnect again. Please, just work with me here," Adora's voice was stressed and Catra knew she was pushing it with Adora.

"Yeah, sorry Captain," Catra muttered apologetically, "Chief Glimmer Moon is on floor 5, potentially 4 but I don't think so. The shooters are aware of her status as Chief. No shots fired," *yet*, Catra added mentally, "I think they're trying to use her as a bargaining chip," There was a pause on the other side.

"If you believe there's no immediate risk then scan each floor as planned. Make sure any other civilians in the building have evacuated before making contact with the hostage," Adora instructed- the *logical* approach, "please work with haste though," Adora reminded, because the building could blow at any moment. Catra walked through the whole floor with caution, holding her gun out ready to shoot when she heard shuffling within a store. She paused, staring at the roller wall covering it- seemingly locked but potentially *not*. She grabbed the bottom and lifted it. Scorpia and Seahawk stood holding her at gunpoint, "It's just me!" Catra shrieked.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia cried, grabbing Catra and hugging her, "these are all the people we could find," Catra felt her chest tighten as a claustrophobic fear took over.

"Get off!" Catra cried out, pushing Scorpia off her, "why haven't you-" Catra cut herself off when she saw the group of civilians, all huddled behind a counter. She spotted the frantic woman from earlier in the crowd and gave her a little nod of recognition. Catra quickly stepped into the shop and closed the roller door behind

her, “Officer D’ream and Hawk located, along with a group of civilians,” Catra reported over the radio, “stand by, Grey,”

“How’d you get in here?” Scorpia gasped, looking like she didn’t even believe Catra was here.

“Through the vent. Why the hell haven’t you said anything over the comms?” Catra ridiculed.

“The gunmen shot up our transceivers,” SeaHawk informed, “fear not though! We have kept the-”

“Now is not the fucking time!” Catra yelled, “what happened to the ‘gunmen’?”

“Scorpia… put them to sleep,” SeaHawk muttered, glancing over to a child. Catra pinched the bridge of her nose,

“Uh huh, and how many of them are taking a prolonged nap?”

“Two,” Scorpia responded.

“Give me five minutes,” Catra said, leaving the room, “Grey, come in,”

“Right here, Weaver,” Adora responded. Catra let her voice sink in for a few moments, allowing herself a brief moment to relax and alleviate some anxiety- “Sarge?”

“Sorry,” Catra muttered, “Two more shooters down and there’s still fucking more. I thought there were only two active shooters?”

“It’s what D’ream and Hawk told us before they disconnected,” Adora said, “how are the civilians?”

“All unharmed. How do we get them out? Most of them can’t fit through the vent,” There was silence on the other end, before Adora chimed in.

“How’s your night vision?” Adora asked. Catra frowned.

“As good as always,” She responded, knowing Adora understood how clear her vision was in the dark

“The windows are fitted with alarms that will go off if you break a window. If we shut down the building’s power the lights will turn off but so will the alarms. We can situate a forklift by any window. We’ll also set up a squad to come up and assist once they’re situated with night gear. We can’t turn the lights back on because the alarms will blarecand we don't want to trigger the shooters into setting of the bombs,”

“Copy that. I’ll lead the group to a front-facing window and command when to shut down the power,” Catra instructed, “over,” Then she walked back to the group, “everyone follow me,” D’ream and Hawk assisted in leading the hostages towards the front window. Catra grabbed her flashlight from her belt and shined it at the window, “you see the light? that’s our window,” Catra said over the comms,

“Copy that, situating the forklift now,” Adora responded. Catra let out an exhale, finding some relief. It was short lived, when Catra heard shuffling and a gun click out of its safety. Catra panicked

“Cut the power,” Catra whispered quickly into the radio. The whole building shut down, lights turning off. Catra’s eyes quickly adjusted to the dark, looking around for the person with the gun. *Nothing*. They were backed up against a window, with someone hidden holding a gun in complete darkness and the only person that could see anything was Catra. Suddenly, someone moved. Catra’s eyes shot to the sound and instantly spotted a man and his gun. Catra’s hand moved before she could even think and another loud bang echoed in the building.

Catra watched the man collapse to the ground.

“Shooter down,” Catra whispered to Adora through the radio. Her eyes were trained. unable to look away as the shooter stilled on the ground, blood pooling around him. *Dead, dead, dead.* She swallowed saliva down her dry throat. A kid started crying. Her

eyes flicked down to them, watching them wail. Catra felt sick as she knelt down to the kid, “I need you to be quiet,” She said softly, trying not to force the child to shut up with a hand over their mouth. They didn’t listen, they just kept crying and screaming. Catra, whilst she concentrated, could hear people on the floor above, questioning the gunshots. Unsure about what to do, Catra switched on her flashlight and put it on the lowest setting. She started purring and put her tail in the little kid's hand. Their bawling paused as they curiously felt her tail. The little kid reached for her ears. She lowered her head and they grabbed gently, smiling as they felt her soft ears. Everyone stared at them in silence but Catra just ignored them, right up until Adora’s voice crackled through on the comms.

“Is everyone wearing closed toe shoes?” Adora asked. Catra’s eyes flitted through everyone's feet.

“Yeah,”

“Alright then, don’t worry about the glass, just smash the window. There's a forklift there,” Adora instructed.

“Copy that,” Catra responded, then turned to the group, “everyone cover your ears,” once everyone had done so, she aimed her gun at the window and shot. The window shattered and Scorpia, SeaHawk and Catra began helping people onto the platform, “you guys go,” Catra said to Scorpia and SeaHawk.

“I’m staying,” Scorpia asserted. SeaHawk looked around nervously.

“Hawk you have to go, Mermista needs you,” His pregnant wife, Mermista, was bound to go into labour any day now. SeaHawk nodded.

“Thank you,” He said, stepping onto the platform.

“Scorp you can’t see in the dark,” Catra added, “you gotta go,”

“Waiting for your signal on the forklift,” Adora reminded.

“I’m not going Wildcat!” Scorpia insisted, “you need me here!”

“You’ll have to use your flashlight, you may as well turn yourself into a giant spotlight and you don’t even have a radio,” Catra scoffed. Scorpia didn’t respond, instead crossing her arms almost petulantly, “you’re a liability,” Catra finally sneered, shoving Scorpia onto the platform, “lower the forklift,” Catra said over the radio. The platform began lowering instantaneously, Catra and Scorpia sharing defeated eye contact. Catra pretended not to notice the tears welling in Scorpia’s eyes as she turned around.

“Civilians made it to the ground. Good work, Weaver,” Adora updated, “how are you?”

“Haven’t been hurt since the shove, I’m fine,”

“I know, but mentally…?” Adora went silent, allowing Catra to fill the air. Catra sighed.

“I’m a little shaken up, but not compromised. I can do this,” Catra said with determination. She heard a soft sigh on the other side.

“I believe in you,” Adora muttered, “finish scanning your floor and then get on to the forklift.”

“What?” Catra asked.

“Finish scanning your-”

“No, I heard you, Grey, but I’m not staying put. The building is a fucking bomb,” Catra rebuked. Adora sighed.

“This is an official Police communication line, please keep it formal,” Adora muttered.

“Sorry Captain,” Catra said quietly, “I'm moving onto the next floor,”

“*Weaver*,” Adora warned. “Come down. You can’t do this on your own,” Adora tried to bargain, “backup will be there soon-”

"How soon? 'Cause you're full of shit," Catra challenged. Adora sighed, because Catra was right.

"There's no night vision gear in the whole area. We're in the process of outsourcing it, estimated to take over an hour,"

"We don't have an hour!" Catra argued, staring out the window down to where she could see cops congregating in front of the mall.

Adora let out a frustrated sigh. "I know, but there's no way I'm going to encourage you to stay in there," Adora groaned, "you gotta come out,"

"Can't you just believe in me?!"

"I do!" Adora yelled back, "if you were anyone else I would've gotten you out immediately because no one is skilled in the way you are. But you're also facing unpredictable situations. We don't know when those bombs are going off and there are shooters that will gun you down on sight. So don't get *pissy* with me when I want you out of there." Adora asserted. Catra went silent.

"Alright," She cowered. "I'm not backing down though. So work with me here," Catra was stubborn and determined.

"Fine, head forth to the next floor and keep me posted,"

"Copy that. Over," Catra said with relief.

<u>Adora - Now</u>

"Keep your girl on a leash, Captain Grey," Officer James Perez hollered at her. Adora's eyes shot up to them.

"Excuse me?" She barked. Officer Perez immediately stopped and flushed red, "we're outside of a building that can explode at any minute and that *'girl'* is trying to get everyone out! How dare you say that?!" Adora felt a surge of rage flood in, "I've been operating this scene from the outside for three hours, with little

idea on what the fuck is going on inside and she is doing her fucking best based on the info she has and you're telling me to keep her on a leash?!"

"Captain Grey," Bow muttered, "he's not worth it," Adora paused, watching the Officer tremble.

"Go and patrol the streets, make sure all the civilians are obeying the evacuation order," Adora dismissed. Once he was gone, Adora muttered under her breath, "useless piece of shit,"

"Why don't you send Catra a bomb suit with the forklift?"

"She'd never put one on. It ruins her agility and her stealth. Also range of motion," Adora sighed, "if this building explodes, I'm going in to get her,"

"Grey, come in," Catra said over the radio. Adora quickly held it to her ear and listened closely.

"I'm here,"

"One armed woman and another unarmed man spotted on the third floor. She's using a handgun. Proceeding with caution,"

"Wait!" Adora yelped, but she knew it was useless to get Catra to back down, "just be careful. See if you can shoot before engaging in direct contact. Remember, you can see in the dark and they can't. If they've got night vision goggles, aim for the eyes and get the advantage,"

"Got it, Grey," Catra responded. Moments later Adora heard dull sounds of muffled gunshots. Adora couldn't do anything but pray it wasn't Catra getting shot. In the long time in which the radio line was silent, Adora couldn't do anything. She was paralysed, thinking what she would do if Catra died… until, "Adora?" Catra's voice was ragged and desperate, "they're dead."

"Weaver-"

“Please, can you just use my name? I just want someone to care about *me*, not my job,” Catra was crying. Adora couldn’t hear the extent of it, but she knew it was bad. Adora took a deep breath.

“I do care about you, Catra,” Adora sighed, “are you alright? You sound pretty fucked up,” Adora knew how unprofessional she sounded, but it was exactly what Catra needed.

“I’ve been punched in the ribs,” Catra responded, “but they’re *dead*. Not even the first. Fuck, Adora,”

Adora stared up at the building, to the floor Catra was on. It’s not like she could see Catra- the whole building was shut down- but she wanted to imagine that Catra was looking back. “Run me through your injuries. I’m worried,”

“Hurt ribs on my left side. It’s already bruising.”

“Can you leave your microphone on and breathe in deeply?” Adora requested. She listened to Catra’s breathing, hearing it stutter then halt as she cried out, “that’s probably fractured, Cat,”

“It’s okay,” Catra dismissed with a sniffle. There was shuffling on the other side, “I’m standing,”

“How’s the pain out of ten?”

“Probably a four. We’ve done more in worse pain,” Adora knew that Catra’s fours were worse than they seem. Catra just had a pain tolerance only matched by Adora. Their childhood built them that way. But Adora knew that Catra couldn’t handle being told to leave the building. Right now, Catra needed support.

“Yeah we have,” Adora agreed after a long silence, “and in spite of all that and more you’re the strongest person I know,” Adora began.

“What?” Catra whispered in disbelief.

“It’s incredible, really. You’re working this situation with diligence. Anyone else, including me, would crack under the pressure. I’m so proud of you for doing your best. But you can’t save everyone,” Adora paused for a moment, staring at the pavement, “it’s funny, ‘cause we saw each other grow up and we always wanted to have cool jobs like this when we were little. It feels really fucking not cool when you’re living it and doing this but if little Catra saw you now, she’d be proud of you too,” Adora's aimless rambling came to an end but Catra’s side of the line stayed silent.

“Do you mean that?” Catra mumbled, barely audible through the comms.

“Yeah,” Adora responded.

“Thank you,” Catra sniffled quietly. Adora stared at the building once again, “I’m gonna continue scanning the area. But can you just talk to me? It's keeping me sharp,”

“Yeah sure,” Adora agreed, “when you get out of there, I’m gonna buy you a drink. Do you still drink whiskey?”

“Yeah, I do,” Catra affirmed with a small laugh.

“Perfect.” Adora grinned widely, sitting down on the pavement, “might be a bad time to ask this, but would you ever leave the force? Just curious.”

“I think if I had a kid, I’d consider it,” Catra mulled it over, “but I’d wanna stay in the force to make sure it's a safe place for people like my kid,”

“Yeah, there's a lot of corruption and abuse of power,” Adora agreed disappointedly. She wasn’t sure if she should really be talking about major problems in an Official Police Communication Line, but she didn’t quite care.

“What about you? Would you leave the force?” Catra asked.

“Honestly? I wish I could,” Adora admitted, “obviously not right now, and god am I fucking glad I get to control this scene from the outside because let me tell you, I would not trust a single other person doing this, but I dunno, I’ve always wanted to quit,”

“Why don’t you?” Catra muttered. Adora let out a lengthy sigh, sitting down for the first time since she arrived at the scene.

“I’m good at this police stuff. I’m important to the force. I’m strong and I guess, the force needs people. It can’t run without us.” Adora reasoned, picking at her hangnails. She could feel Bow watching her, probably questioning why she’s opening up about this to her ex-wife and why Adora never told him.

“That’s ridiculous,” Catra responded crassly, “this line of work is clearly not fulfilling you Adora, that’s not your fault. You shouldn’t force yourself to stay doing this.”

“You have a good point,” Adora laughed, “maybe I’ll consider it after today. But all I’m focused on is getting you out.”

“You say that like it’s guaranteed,” Catra chuckled pensively. Adora’s heart stopped, wondering how Catra spoke so recklessly.

“You *are*, Catra,” Adora would never let Catra die there. She would sacrifice herself if she had to.

“C’mon. Be realistic here,” Catra muttered, “it’s alright. There's nothing for me anyways.” Adora wanted to throw up.

“Surely there’s *something*,” Adora probes.

<u>Catra - 3 years ago</u>

After a month of living with Scorpia, Catra had finally moved out. It was official. Her and Adora were done. Neither of them had sent each other divorce papers but she didn’t need stupid forms to see how burnt the bridge between them was. Catra collapsed onto her mattress and cried. Catra was convinced of one thing- that Adora would never trust her. So she pushed Adora away,

made sure any conversation between the two of them would end in fighting and yelling.

It worked. Adora was gone from her life. Aside from work, but really, they just pretended like they didn't even know each other. Adora was removed from her life, uprooted as though she were just a weed in the garden and thrown into the bin. Now Catra's home felt so empty. All she had was her bed, a seat and a few boxes of her stuff, yet to be unpacked. It was a bare apartment, one that despite how cushy it was could never feel warm because it wasn't *home*.

Honestly, it'd be shallow to blame their whole messy separation on Glimmer. She sowed the insecurity within Catra, but it was their own problems that watered the seed. Nothing was quite right before it. Adora and Catra had issues, they both knew this. They were going to talk about it at the end of the week, when they both had *time*. But the end of the week didn't arrive for their relationship. Catra had blown it all up.

Adora had taken all of her friends. Every single one grew vindictive of Catra. Even Scorpia, who started dating Adora's friend, started being distant.

The light in her life had been blown out. The dark was all that was left.

Catra was empty. The world was an awful, bleak place.

<u>Catra - Now</u>

"Nope, there's uh… truly nothing. Um, moving onto the fifth floor," Catra said on the radio, arriving at the bottom of the stairs.

"Move with caution, Weaver," Adora responded. *Back to cordial.* Catra felt iced out.

"Got it, Grey," Catra muttered.

“You’re going into a hostage situation. This means negotiation. Don’t let them know about your rib, make it look like you have the upper hand.”

“Thanks,” Catra responded dryly. She had to adjust the way she was standing to make sure she wasn’t leaning into her hurt rib. It was painful, but she could do it with a straight face. Slowly, she walked up the stairs with her gun drawn. She stopped instantly at the sound of voices.

“When are your cop friends arriving?” A gunman said. The sound of shoving followed, paired with it a shriek from Glimmer. Catra’s eyes widened as she questioned whether to intervene or not. But they were criminals, not idiots. They wouldn’t kill their only advantage.

“I don’t know! They’re just being careful. It’ll be any minute now,” Glimmer assured. Catra took a deep breath, settled half way up the stairs. Her rib throbbed with pain but it was ignorable.

“Grey, come in,” Catra whispered.

“Yeah, I’m here,”

“I’m about to engage with the shooters.”

“I’ve already given you the go ahead.”

“I know, it’s just… I’m probably not making it out so…”

“*Weaver*,” Adora warned. Catra could hear the nervousness in her voice.

“I just, I just wanted to say, I wish things worked out between us. I… I’m sorry for everything,” Catra mumbled. Without waiting for a response, Catra quickly added after; “stay silent, engaging immediately. Have the forklift ready for Glimmer,”

“And you,” Adora corrected.

"*Quiet*," Catra ridiculed. She knew she wouldn't make it out of there. She finally got up the stairs, looking to where a flashlight lit up three shooters and *Glimmer*, "Sparkles' little cop friend arrived," Catra called out, hiding behind a pillar. The gunmen went silent and shined their lights towards her voice.

"Come out and play, little sister," One of the men called out. Catra shivered.

"What's your name?"

"Call me Prime," He responded.

"And the two others?" Catra asked. She snuck behind a stall.

"Prime 2 and Prime 3,"

"Self centered, much?" Catra scoffed.

"Little sister, it would be so much easier if you came out into the light. We've been expecting someone like you," Catra peaked above the stall, "though I must say, I did not expect the building to be so intact." Catra quickly shot the two men not holding Glimmer. As their dead bodies dropped to the ground, Prime let out a laugh. "How unfortunate," He cocked his gun and pointed it at Glimmer, grabbing her hair to keep her in place, "I will give you another chance, little sister, for my minions are disposable. I do think you're forgetting who has the upper hand here. I have your friend held at gunpoint and a detonator in my pocket to set off *all* the bombs if things go terribly. You best be careful," Prime advised.

"Believe me, she's not my friend," Catra laughed, appearing before Prime. She saw Glimmer next to him, unarmed and not in uniform. She must've been doing late night shopping or something stupid and been followed by Prime and his freak groups.

"How did you manage to get in, little sister?" Prime asked, looking at her curiously.

“You didn’t block off the vents,” Catra responded. Prime looked amused as he laughed to himself.

“Forgive me, for I did not think anyone would be able to fit through it,”

“For fucks sake! I’m not that short,” Catra groaned, “Now give me one reason I shouldn’t shoot you, her and then me?” Catra threatened as she held her gun up. Prime looked disturbed and Glimmer’s whole face went pale as she looked up at Catra.

“And why would you ever do that?” Prime inquired, clearly curious but confused.

“*She* caused the divorce between me and my ex-wife, *I* haven’t felt much of anything since and *you*? You’re just being a pain in my ass.” A silence enveloped them both. Glimmer looked up at Catra terrified.

“You’ve gone rogue,” Glimmer whispered, eyes widened with terror.

“Yeah, Sparkles. I have,” Catra lied. If Glimmer knew she was lying, then it’d blow her cover. She had to feast on Glimmer believing her.

“I never meant for everything to go so badly! I- *please* don’t kill me!” Glimmer begged before getting shoved by Prime- a sign for her to shut up. Catra snorted, like it was funny, even though the very action made Catra sick with anxiety.

“So what’s it gonna be, Prime?” She smiled fakely, looking up at him and pointing her gun at him, “are we gonna work together? Or is it going to end in us all dead. Honestly, I don’t care either way.”

“I want to start this world anew,” He smiled back at her. It was eerie, “and that begins with the Chief of Police dead and someone to broadcast my message to the world,” Catra can hear just how fast Glimmer’s heart rate has picked up.

“And what fucking message is that,”

“That salvation is coming-” In his distracted moments, Catra ran forward and grabbed the gun.

“Run!” She screamed at Glimmer. “Go to the second floor window! There's a forklift!” Glimmer was gone and Prime blindly shot his gun as Catra grabbed it and *attacked* him- kicking him, yanking his leg, doing anything so Glimmer could get away. The gun kept shooting until a bullet finally landed-

Catra was shot.

She let out a loud scream, then felt a hand lift her by the hair. She yelled and flailed, feeling his hand snake to her neck and hold her up there.

“Little sister. You could have cooperated,” He studied her face curiously, turning it from side to side. His hand clutched her throat tighter and she fought for air. He loosened his hand *ever so slightly*, allowing Catra to get just enough air. Catra’s hand scrabbled weekly at his wrist, but the pain was getting to her. *Weak*.

“I’m not your little sister,” Catra spat in his face. Tears were streaming down her eyes as she groaned, clutching the bullet wound and trying to stop the blood. He smiled at her efforts, wiping the spit off with his gun and then inspecting it.

“Oh wow. Courageous for such a hurt animal,” He drawled, shoving the gun under her chin. “You were lying about going rogue, yes?”

“What the fuck do you want?!”

“I just want to heal you. I see you, little sister, your mind ensnared in rage and grief. You may have been lying before, but the best lies are wrapped in truth. Your ex-wife left you, that is still true, yes? And you are all alone, living in a world where *no one* cares for you,”

“You don’t know anything!” Catra denied, struggling against Prime’s hold.

“I could turn you into my vessel, bend you to my will. *I care for you*, little sister,”

“I will never work with a beast like you,” Catra hissed. Prime squeezed her throat and Catra gasped,

“Such a defiant little thing, you are. It would be fun to push your limits, see how long it takes to break you. But your little *frenemy* has likely gone and snitched that you’re in danger. So I’ll end your suffering, little sister. I could've done it peacefully, had you cooperated with me. But now?”

“Weaver, come in. Glimmer made it out. Where the hell are you?!” Adora’s voice overlapped with Prime’s next words

“I’m going to shoot you,” Before he could. Catra kicked at his pocket. His eyes widened as he realised what she had done. The explosions began just a split second later. Prime dropped Catra to the ground in shock. The whole building shook as the bombs began to go off.

Chapter 3

Adora - Now

Adora watched with horror as all the bombs began to explode, the building turning into one massive firework. “Fuck!” She screamed, watching each floor fall through. The roof might’ve been the only part of the mall that wasn’t lined with bombs. It remained unsteady as the walls began to break but the roof had not collapsed yet. “Weaver!” Adora screamed over the comms, desperate to get some kind of response, “Sergeant Weaver! Do you copy?!” She paused, hand shaking violently as she clutched onto her radio. She looked at the burning building in flames right in front of her. Tears welled in her eyes and a deep pit of anxiety brewed in her stomach at the lack of response, “Fuck! Catra, baby, *please*,”

“I’m here,” Catra choked out, her voice just not overshadowed by the crushing sounds of the building collapsing with her still inside, “I’m alive.” Adora started sprinting towards the building.

“Where are you? I’m coming,” Adora yelled, the cars blocking the front door had exploded to rubble, and now the doorway was clear. She ran straight in, despite everyone telling her not to. There was only so long before the roof caved in and crushed Catra. Adora had to get her out.

“I don't know,” Catra sobbed. “I love you so much, Adora-” Whilst trying to speak, Catra let out a horrifying scream- one that came from the depths of her chest from all the pain, “get yourself safe!” Catra pleaded through a screamed sob, her voice ragged.

“Not without you!” Adora yelled, She ran across the rubble, tripping and struggling in the bomb suit but she didn’t stop. She kept going, using her flashlight to look for Catra amidst all the fire and rubble.

“I see you!” Catra cried out into the radio. Adora could only hear her because the radio was right next to her ear. The echo of the collapse and the raging fire was too loud to hear anything else.

“Where?!”

“Left,” Catra groaned. Adora's head shot to her left and she moved the flashlight along with it, spotting Catra on top of a broken slab of concrete.

“Catra!” She yelled out, grabbing her and picking her up. Rubble around Catra's knee fell off and a bone was sticking out. Adora's eyes trailed up to where she saw *red*, “you're shot?!” She stressed, before quickly looking around. The exit had fallen through. *They were stuck*, Catra was coughing in Adora’s arms, all the smoke getting to her, and the bullet wound was *still* bleeding, “*fuck*, Catra, I love you, I don’t wanna die, I-” She cut herself off as she started sobbing.

“Adora,” Catra said. Adora could barely hear her, “it’s okay, we’ll make it out. We always do,” Catra assured weakly. Adora nodded and held Catra close to her chest as she looked around, “I love you,” Catra whispered back. *Finally* a bright beam of light flashed onto Adora. They both looked towards it and saw someone shining a large torch through *an exit*! Adora ran as fast as she could in the bomb suit with Catra in her arms.

They were finally out.

But when Adora looked down, Catra’s eyes were shut and her body was limp, “No, no, no, no! Come *on* Catra! You said *we* were making it out!” she cried, shaking Catra a little. Adora almost puked at the way she moved lifelessly, “Someone! Help!” Adora screamed. Paramedics quickly came over and took Catra from Adora. Adora followed swiftly, right until they were getting in the ambulance, “I’m her wife,” she said, getting into the van with them. In the ambulance van, they situated Catra with an oxygen mask and began fixing up her bullet wound. But Catra wasn’t

making a sound. Adora took off her bomb suit mask. They stabbed her with a needle, much to Adora's mortification.

"Do you know her blood type?" One of the EMTs asked. They did chest compressions on her but Catra's body moved like a ragdoll *lifelessly*.

"O negative," Adora responded with her mind all over the place, "she um, donates a lot of blood because of it," Adora acted like she knew whether that was still true.

"Good to hear," Then over the radio, the EMT called for O negative blood to be ready at the hospital. Adora looked down to Catra's bullet wound. There was blood everywhere- over Catra's uniform, on the stretcher, *all over Adora*, "pulse is getting weaker," An EMT inserted an IV to her wrist.

"Catra, please," Adora sobbed, holding onto her hand. It was clammy and cold, *not like Catra*. But then… a miracle.

Catra began to cough.

Adora's eyes shot wide as Catra coughed and coughed and coughed. Then she opened her eyes and her gaze lingered on Adora weakly, "hey Adora,"

"Catra!" Adora gasped, clutching her hand tighter. Catra let out a loud cry as an EMT applied more pressure to the bullet wound. She tried to push their hand away. Adora quickly grabbed her free hand, the EMT shooting her a grateful look, "they're helping you! I promise,"

"It hurts," Catra sobbed.

"I know," Adora affirmed, eyes watery. Catra shrieked as an EMT jostled the wound, "she hurt her ribs as well-"

"She's hurt just about everywhere. She fell 5 floors with a bullet wound. It's a miracle she even survived," The EMT responded. Adora frowned, this wasn't a *miracle*. She understood what they

were trying to say but *still*. How insensitive. Catra whimpered out in pain and Adora clutched her hand tightly.

"Almost at the hospital!" The driver called out. Everyone prepared to leave the van.

Catra- Now

Catra woke up to the sound of beeping and gloved hands handling her arms. Catra groaned and opened her eyes, to be met with blurry vision. She looked around herself, noticing the wires attached to her, "fuck," Catra whispered anxiously. She tried to move but a doctor stopped her.

"Please, stay still," Catra looked up at them and saw Prime- the man from the mall. The man who *shot* her. She shrieked and shoved him. Looking at all of them, she realised they were all him, like he had been cloned a thousand times. Instantly she went into flight mode, trying to escape the wires she was tethered to. *So many wires.*

"Let me go!" Catra screamed, but it sounded distorted. She pulled on the cords attached to her, hearing loud beepings and alarms blaring. Pain rippled in the top of her hand where one of the wires had been tugged out and when Catra looked down she saw red.

A whole lot of red.

She shoved the white blanket off her, seeing most of her body covered in bandages and casts. As she went to claw then off she felt a hand grab her wrist and yank it away, "Catra!" Adora shouted. Catra looked up to see *Adora* by the side of the bed. Instantly her struggling halted and her face turned horrified.

"Adora," She sobbed, "they're coming for me. You have to stop him," Adora brought Catra into a tight hug and tucked Catra's head into the crook of her neck. Unable to see what was happening, Catra felt a sharp feeling in the top of her hand. She tried to pull away to look but Adora kept her there. She didn't mind too much though, because she was safe there, "he's here,"

“Who’s here?” Adora asked.

“Prime. They’re all working with him,” Catra fretted. Adora paused, making sure to hold Catra’s head.

“You’re coming out of a coma. Whatever you think is happening isn’t,” Adora assured but Catra went rigid. *Adora’s lying. But Adora wouldn’t lie*, “you're okay, Catra,” Adora whispered. *Adora wouldn’t lie. Then this can’t be Adora.*

“You’re not real,” Catra resolved, “you’re fake!” She shoved Adora off her. Adora looked terrified.

“It’s really me!”

“No! Adora hates me! You’re not her!” Catra shouted back, “Don’t come near me!” She shrieked, tugging the blanket over her.

Catra started hyperventilating, her breathing picking up and going far too fast… until she realised how tired she was. Her whole body ached. Her waist was numb. She couldn’t really move her legs properly. *Under the blanket. Safe.* Catra stopped fighting what her body wanted and let her eyes close slowly.

<u>Adora- Now</u>

Adora looked down at Catra’s unconscious body, the doctors aligning her back to lay in bed. “Don’t worry, that kind of reaction is normal after a medically induced coma. The last thing she likely remembers is a traumatic event, and now she’s trying to make sense of her situation,” The doctor explained.

“She was only in a coma for a couple of days though,” Adora reasoned. She had never seen Catra so disturbed by her surroundings- she’d been scared enough to rip out her IV.

“As short as it may seem, it’s still fairly disorientating,” The doctor seemed sympathetic to Adora’s situation, “she’s going to need *time*, but don't let the way she just acted scare you. Her next time

waking up might be different." Adora nodded, holding Catra's hand.

That night Adora sobbed, as she had all nights since the crime scene. Her bones were weary from the restless sleep she'd been having the past few nights. Catra was her ex-wife, yet she was so much more than that. She was Adora's childhood best friend, her first kiss, her first love, her *only love*. Her love for Catra never strayed, regardless of their three year separation or the fights they had leading up to it. Now Adora would give anything to go back in time and take back the lost time.

Catra admitted she loved Adora, and Adora viceversa.

But was love enough?

Adora sighed, looking up to her ceiling in the dark. Before coming home, Adora had stopped by Glimmer's house.

Something about the way Catra screamed about Prime seemed too real- less like a made up story and more like a bad memory. So Adora asked Glimmer about it, wondering if it had anything to do with the mall crime scene. Glimmer's eyes darkened upon explaining to Adora who Prime was. Glimmer told Adora everything- the way Catra pretended to be corrupt, threatened Glimmer's life and then sacrificed her own just so Glimmer could get away.

Now Adora was alone in bed, regretting having ever let go of Catra for the last three years of her life. It was 2am and Adora was yet to get a wink of sleep. Her brain was switched on, running at full speed, ready for anything. When her phone buzzed, she shot up in bed and grabbed it, but it wasn't the hospital, just some useless app she didn't even care about. Adora let out a loud groan, in need of sleep. She purged all the apps on her phone and laid back down, but felt restless.

When her alarm went off at 7AM, she started crying again. Adora hadn't gotten any sleep. She pulled herself out of bed, trying to

erase the images in her head of Catra *dead* in her arms. She needed to see Catra alive and breathing. She grabbed her keys and went to go to her car when a wave of exhaustion hit her. *Can't drive*. She put her keys back down and called Bow.

"Adora?" Bow answered the phone confused.

"I need to see *her*," Adora pleaded, choking on her sobs, "can you drive me?"

"What's wrong?" Bow asked softly. Adora heard the jingling of keys in the background.

"I can't drive, but I need to see Catra," Adora could barely get her words out with the way her breathing was speeding up, "I have to,"

"I'm on my way," Bow assured. He kept Adora on the phone as he drove over. When he arrived, Adora was ready to go right to Catra but Bow stopped her, "Adora, come with me," Bow said, leading Adora to the kitchen and getting her to sit down. Adora didn't want to argue- Bow was driving her to the hospital- but she was fidgety as she sat on the stool. Her leg wouldn't stop bouncing and she picked at her raw hangnails. Bow filled the kettle with water and put it on the stove.

"Why are you boiling water?" Adora asked with a frown, "we need to go-"

"No Adora," Bow said softly, reaching out to hold one of her hands to stop her from picking, "we're going to drink some tea and relax."

"It's urgent!" Adora snapped.

"I know," Bow responded, "but you're not going like this," Adora let out a long sigh, collapsing her face into her hands. The tears came back with the flashes of Catra. *Catra smiling. Catra when they were arguing. Catra dead in her arms.* Bow rubbed Adora's

shoulder and brought her into a hug. Adora wanted to wipe her memory and forget it all.

“I wasted three years fighting with her when I could’ve fucking lost her forever! I can’t waste more time!” Adora cried. “she was *limp!*”

“I know,” Bow muttered, “but she’s alive now. And Catra is *stubborn*. She’s going to be okay. You aren’t if you push yourself like this. Why don’t we lay down on the couch for a little?” Adora followed numbly to the floor of the living room and let Bow lay her down. It was nice- a break from the thoughts. *The thoughts*. *Catra- dead.* They flooded back in and Adora felt tears prick her eyes, “breathe in deeply,” Bow instructed. Adora followed.

“God, she was lifeless,” Adora sobbed, hugging Bow closely from where he was sitting next to the couch, “it’s all my fault. Why am I always ruining things?” Adora broke down and Bow let out a deep exhale.

“It’s not your fault,”

“I should’ve gotten her out earlier and then she would be safe. We would’ve figured it out with Glimmer. Maybe everyone would be alive and Catra wouldn’t be-”

“Catra would’ve done what she did either way. You knew you couldn’t get her out of that building,” Bow asserted, “things seem terrible now, but that doesn’t make it your fault,”

“You don’t get it,” Adora cried, “I’m like a bad omen,”

“You haven’t hurt me,” Bow reasoned, “and that isn’t true. You’ve made mistakes but you learn from them. That’s what makes you so great! You always want to learn,”

“I’m a ruiner,” Adora muttered, “it's why Catra left me in the first place,”

“No, Adora,” Bow said, his voice low, “Glimmer completely messed things up for you, fed into both of your insecurities. I know you’ve spoken about that and you’ve forgiven her, but Catra left you because she was insecure. That’s not a good foundation for a relationship,”

“I ruined things with the mall. It ended up exploding!” Adora justified, her mind set in her being a bad person.

“You know there's no way you could’ve changed how things went,”

“But she was *dead*. There was *so* much blood,”

“That must’ve been scary,” Bow affirmed, “but it’s over, and regardless of anything, you can’t change the past,”

“It’s over,” Adora repeated, taking a deep breath. She was exhausted- eyes begging to be closed and her body aching for rest.

“Yeah, now let’s take a nap,” Bow encouraged. Adora nodded, wiping her eyes. She let go of Bow and curled up. Bow put a blanket over Adora and let her sleep.

<u>Catra- Three years ago</u>

Catra was sitting on the couch in her apartment, killing time by aimlessly looking through Netflix. A knock echoed in the small room. Catra’s eyebrows furrowed as she approached the door. When she opened it, Adora was standing there, “Catra,” She panted out, cheeks blushing and her eyes wide. Adora had clearly ran up the stairs or done *something* stupid to be this breathless.

“Get fucked,” Catra responded, closing the door. Adora stopped her.

“No Catra, please,” she begged, out of breath and struggling for air, “I just… *please*,”

“Please *what*, Adora? I don’t have all day,” what a lie. Catra had no plans, nowhere to be. She wasn’t even working for the next two days. But the last person she wanted plans with was Adora.

“Can we talk?”

“We are, idiot,”

“I know but-” Adora pinched the bridge of her nose, “I’m sorry, Catra. I know I fucked up,” Adora’s eyes were glossy, “I messed up everything, I know. I screwed up. I just need a chance. I can’t- I can’t let go of this, Catra, I can’t let go of *us,*” Adora had tears streaming down her face, her voice thick and shaky. Adora was desperate to talk.

“You’re still friends with Sparkles, aren’t you?” Catra interrogated. The guilty look in Adora’s eyes gave Catra her answer, “after all she did you’re still wrapped around her finger,” Catra sneered, “fuck you Adora,”

“I’m not… wrapped around her finger,” Adora said quietly, “I talked things through with her. And we can too! Please, don’t just give up,”

“Nothing to give up on if it’s already gone,” Catra responded, her voice cold and calculated. Adora’s eyes widened.

“What?”

“You heard me. It’s fucking over. I don’t want to be with someone who treated me the way you did.”

“Ok,” Adora said quietly. Things were crystal clear to Adora. She was a ruiner. A scar on smooth skin. *The fault of everything terrible*, “I’m sorry,” Adora muttered, defeated. It wasn’t a plea like before though. It was the nail in the coffin. The time of death on their love, “I know it means nothing, but I am. I wish I didn’t ruin things. I think it might be one of the only things I’m good at,” Adora agreed, then walked away. Catra shut the door quietly and collapsed against it. Catra had shut her out, once again. Like

always. Kept Adora away. This time it was for good. Adora was not the one who ruined everything. Catra was. Catra knew it. She always had. She ended up alone. As the woman who raised her always thought she would be. She always knew she ruined things. She reacted too quickly, was too stubborn. *The fault of everything terrible*. Tears streamed down her face as she stuck to the floor like glue, bound to the ground. She was made to die alone.

Alone.

Cold.

<u>Catra- Now</u>

Cold.

Everything was cold.

Catra vaguely remembered waking up a while ago. Flashes of machines, wires, *Adora*? *Prime?* Her memory was a blur, like when she drank too much. Except she didn't this time- she just fell down a five story building with a bullet hole in her.

Oh.

The events come flooding back in, everything that happened in the mall. It made her need to open her eyes. For all she knew she was dead, and this was just one painful purgatory before she walked right to whatever afterlife was waiting for her. Everything was *so* heavy and her eyelids wouldn't cooperate. Finally though, she found the strength to open her eyes. *Weak*. As her vision focused, she saw a hospital room. She let out a steady exhale, shifting to sit up. *Pain. Why?* She looked down at her body, bandages around her waist. *Wound. Bullet. Shot*. The reminder made Catra frown. A doctor came in, asked if she wanted them to let her *wife* know she was awake, "Adora?" Catra questioned. Surely Adora wasn't-

"Yeah," The doctor affirmed. She was a nice woman- old but motherly, "she's been visiting every day. I thought you might

prefer if we go over your injuries with her here,”

“It’s okay,” Catra muttered, flushing, “you can just tell me,”

So the doctor did. Catra felt a deep pit of anxiety brew, as she heard every little thing wrong with her she had surgery for. Fractured rib, shattered knee, bullet wound, internal bleeding- the list went on and on and on and on. Catra had tears streaming down her face, but she kept her expression impassive and blank. Apparently she went through countless different surgeries, yet nothing could quite piece back together all her broken parts. She was destroyed, and nothing could change it. Not surgery, not pain meds, nothing. She was a tornado, ripping through others, ruining Adora, ruining *everything*. All she did was cause pain.

She looked to her left and was met with a stack of letters.

“What’s this?” She asked, picking one up.

“They're from some of the people you saved in the fires,” The doctor explained. Catra frowned.

“Why would they send me letters?” Catra muttered.

“Why don’t you read them?” She responded with a smile. Catra raised an eyebrow. The doctor excused herself, giving Catra some privacy and letting her know that she’ll contact Catra’s wife. Catra bit her lip, not wanting to deny that Adora was her wife. She set to opening the first letter. She ran her claw over the top of the first one and unfolded it. Her eyes widened as she took in the letter. It was from one of the civilians she helped escape, saying how indebted they were to Catra helping them escape and wishing her a full recovery. Catra felt her eyes water and her chest swell. She picked up another and another and another and they were *all* people thankful for Catra and her sacrifice. There was even one from Sea Hawk, saying how he would forever be grateful for Catra and how he was glad he was able to go home to Mermista, and that he hoped Catra could go home to her family.

Catra was blushing, surprised at all the love these letters held. For once, she felt like she didn't ruin anything. Sure, a building had exploded and almost killed her, but she'd managed to help people. People were safe and got to go home and spend time with their family. The only thing Catra felt was missing was a family of her own.

She'd only known one girl to truly be her family. That girl happened to be her ex-wife.

But were things really over?

Catra had to believe against it.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra- Two years and six months ago

Catra was tired. She came home to her bare house after another shift and decided enough was enough. She couldn't live like this. No matter how complacent she wanted to be with the empty feeling inside of her, she couldn't continue this way. She needed a friend. Maybe two if she was lucky. After the separation Catra hadn't made new friends, and *god* was she sick of being lonely. The few people she spoke to were distant coworkers, but conversation never really went beyond small talk.

But maybe some of them wanted to be friends. Catra knew Lonnie had invited her out tonight with a couple of others. Catra had shot down the idea then, but now, it seemed like a damn good option. Better than spending another night alone at the very least. She picked up her phone and called her. "Hey," Lonnie said when she picked up.

"Hey, is the offer to hang out still on the table?" Catra asked.

"Yeah, a few others are at mine right now, I'll send you the address," Lonnie responded. They hung up shortly after and Catra left the house, getting into the car. When she arrived at Lonnie's address, she knocked on the door. Lonnie opened, "hey,"

"Hi," Catra responded, before Lonnie was inviting her in.

"That's Entrapta," Lonnie pointed. Entrapta got *reeallly* close to Catra.

"In your car ride over I was able to find all of your personal details!" Entrapta beamed, shaking Catra's hand. Catra looked mortified- when she agreed to a hangout she didn't expect to get *stalked*.

"Uh I know how that sounds but that's just how Entrapta is… she's not being creepy, just curious," Lonnie explained. Entrapta nodded furiously.

"Alright," Catra said skeptically.

"If you want I can erase all private information on you. Though I doubt anyone will really look for it, nor will they have the skills because I used a-" Entrapta rambled and Lonnie cut her off.

"Do you want a drink?" Lonnie asked. Catra nodded

"Yeah, I think I need one,"

<u>Adora- Now</u>

Adora blinked her eyes open and didn't feel like total shit. She had *slept*! She got sleep! "I got sleep!" She exclaimed to Bow

"You did," Bow smiled proudly.

"Can I go see her?" Adora asked like she needed permission. Bow laughed and Adora realised she could drive herself, "nevermind! Thank you so much Bow, I'll- I'll find a way to make it up to you!" She sputtered as she ran out the door with her car keys. In the car, she was buzzing with relief at finally being *physically* able to get to Catra. Even if Catra wasn't awake, she would just get to see her, get the reassurance that Catra's at least okay. Adora pulled into the carpark once she arrived and went through the lobby. She walked up to Catra's room and saw Catra awake. She was *alive* and well, her eyes still cast with that vibrant spark as she talked with other friends.

Friends Adora didn't recognise.

Adora had a quick realisation- Catra had moved on. Adora stayed the same person, devoted to Catra and unable to forget what happened between them. She was always sure Catra didn't feel the same until the night of the mall. Everything they said to each other just felt so real. But Catra had a new life. One without Adora. Adora was okay with that though- it felt like a dagger into Adora's stomach but Catra was well and clearly happier. Honestly at least she was alive, and beggars can't be choosers so- "Hey," Catra called out from her hospital bed. The two strangers next to her turned around to look.

"Hi," Adora was slightly breathless. She gave a small smile. She felt like a deer in headlights.

"Who's that?" One of them asked.

"She's my… my Adora," Catra responded softly. Adora's eyes widened a little upon hearing that, her heart swelling with hope.

"Your pupils just dilated," The other friend observed. Catra shoved her lightly, but Catra's eyes stayed pinned on Adora.

"Come in," Catra said to Adora. Adora walked in awkwardly, "this is Entrapta," Catra introduced, gesturing to the one with purple pigtails who made the comment about Catra's pupils, "and this is Lonnie," Lonnie looked between Catra and Adora.

"We'll give you some privacy," Lonnie grinned, nudging Catra's shoulder. They left the room and Catra's heart started racing. The machine she was hooked up to made it pain-stakingly obvious.

"Do you want me to go?" Adora asked, looking over at the machine.

"No," Catra said softly, "you called me *baby*," Catra grinned. Adora went red and her eyes went wide.

"I'm sorry if I overstepped boundaries," Adora acknowledged, sitting on the edge of the bed, "You've always known how I feel but-"

“Relax, dummy,” Catra said, shoving Adora’s shoulder, “I missed you. Is it… can I hug you?” Catra asks nervously. Adora nods hurriedly.

“Yeah,” She whispers, leaning forward and enveloping Catra. Catra started sniffling, burying her head into Adora’s neck. Adora broke instantly.

“You were dead,” Adora sobbed, “I thought I lost you and- and fucking hell it *wasn’t*-”

“I’m here, Adora,” Catra whispered, cutting her off, “not for lack of trying, but I’m here. Try not to focus on the fact that I wasn’t,”

“Okay,” Adora responded quietly, feeling Catra’s body against hers and breathing deeply, “I know things aren't going to be perfect, but I can't lose you,”

“I don’t want to lose you either,” Catra murmurs, “I don’t want to push you away anymore,” Catra added at the end and let out a deep sigh, “I love you,”

“You said that right before you died,” Adora acknowledged quietly.

“I was *dead*?” Catra questioned in disbelief. Adora nodded, her heart hurting at reliving the memories.

“Completely limp at the very least,” Adora filled in, “I love you too, *so damn much.* Don’t die on me again.”

“I’ll try my best,” Catra joked dryly. Adora hugged tighter.

“Promise me you won’t risk your life like that ever,” Adora pleaded.

“I promise, princess,” Catra assured, meaning it wholeheartedly. Adora shuffled to sit next to Catra on the bed, still cuddling, “what happens next with us?” Catra asked quietly.

“I don’t know. But we’ll figure it out.”

A silence lapsed between them and they both let it happen, scared to break this perfect moment. It was only interrupted when the *queen* of Brightmoon entered. Immediately they both stiffened, "just the two people I wanted to see," Queen Angella started warmly. Adora raised an eyebrow at her friend's mother.

"Do I call you 'your Majesty' or…?" Adora let her voice trail off.

"Nonsense Adora. You too Catra,"

"You know my name?" Catra questioned.

"Yes, well that is something I have to know when awarding you the Medal of Valor," Angella smiled, "your bravery and courage saved the lives of many, including my own daughter, Glimmer. As the queen, I commend you for your service with this award. As a mother, I am endlessly grateful that I got to see my daughter healthy and physically okay after that travesty,"

"All due respect, *your Majesty*-" Catra started, purposefully keeping it formal, "-I didn't save Glimmer because of who she is. I saved her because *no one* deserved to die in that building."

"Yes, Catra, I am well aware," Angella laughed softly at Catra's forwardness, "but I'm still grateful for your service. As for you Adora, I wish to award you with the Meritorious Service Medal," Angella informed warmly. Adora's cheeks flushed at the thought. Even though the Meritorious Service Medal wasn't as highly esteemed as the Medal of Valor, she felt a sense of pride budding in her chest, "I will point out, the stunt you pulled to save Catra was reckless. You left the scene without assigning an operator. Yet I can't say I'd do anything different if I had to save Micah. So I think we're all willing to look past that."

"Thank you, Angella," Adora said with watery eyes, "when's the award ceremony?"

"In a month. I thought I'd give both of you some time to heal and take a break," Angella informed, "well, Adora. You have my number. Please pass it onto Catra and either of you can reach out

at any time. If you have any concerns of timing, transport or anything else, do let me know," Angella let herself out. Catra and Adora stared at each other in shock,

"Holy shit," Catra laughed, "we're getting awarded. That's top shit, Adora!"

"Oh my god," Adora responded in disbelief, "I can't believe it."

"You better, 'cause we have a ceremony to attend in a month," Catra grinned, nestling her head into Adora's chest, "can I ask you something?"

"Anything,"

"How come you made up with Glimmer?" Catra asked softly. She tried her best to not seem upset, but she couldn't help it.

"I know it was bad, but it'd been two months, and Glimmer wanted to talk things through. She understood if I didn't forgive her but told me why she acted that way," Adora sighed, "you wouldn't talk to me regardless of whether I was friends with Glimmer or not. That much I knew. Or at least I thought I did," Catra's ears flattened against her head and she nodded into Adora, "I'm sorry. I know being friends with her really hurt you. I was just so alone," Adora sighed

"Ok," Catra mumbled, "I'm sorry too," Catra knew it was all her fault. If she hadn't been so stubborn and pushed Adora away at every possible moment maybe they could've been happy together. Instead she tried to spurn their relationship to no return.

"Don't be sorry," Adora hushed softly, rubbing Catra's shoulder, "we've both made mistakes, but this definitely isn't your fault," She kissed the top of Catra's head and hugged her, feeling Catra tremble from tears.

"I'm not a good person, Adora," Catra sobbed, burying her face in Adora's chest in a feeble attempt to reject the world around her, "before the mall I'd never fucking done anything good,"

"You know that isn't true. Your very first case you protected a little kit from those corrupt officers, and remember my tenth birthday, when you found enough coins to buy me a gumball? You've always been a good person," Adora assured, whispering the words into Catra's hair, "you… you've just been dealt a bad hand many times in your life. But you're *Catra*. Hard times have never stopped you before. Don't let it stop you now," Amidst her tears, Catra let out a wet purr.

"Fuck," She exhaled. Adora laughed, "I love you so fucking much," Catra grabbed Adora's face and kissed her, her heartbeat thrumming in her ears as a fervent passion overtook Catra.

"I love you too," Adora responded in between kisses, "forever,"

Catra- Now

Catra spent what felt like far too long recovering. She was glad to get discharged from the hospital fairly quickly for injuries as extreme as they were, yet having to be on rest whilst her *wife* went into work everyday was frustrating. Catra was ecstatic to be officially cleared by her doctor to attend the ceremony- even though that wouldn't stop her anyway. As the day of the ceremony approached slowly, Catra grew more and more excited. "I ironed your uniform," Adora called out from the laundry on the day of the ceremony, running in to the bedroom and setting it down, "Angella said to arrive at Brightmoon Castle around nine,"

"That's a whole three hours before it begins," Catra groaned, but she couldn't even fake not being excited. She pulled on her uniform and stepped out into the living room, where Adora was sipping on her coffee.

"Hey you," Adora smiled, kissing Catra, "how're you feeling?"

"Good to be back in uniform," Catra grinned, "a little weird though. Reminds me of the mall," The mall- or rather the memories of it- often plagued the two of them. They were working on it in therapy, of course, but they still flinched at any

sound that resembled a gun shot and felt extra alert of their surroundings. Adora looked concerned.

“Are you gonna be alright? They can’t make you wear the uniform-”

“Relax,” Catra laughed, holding either side of Adora’s face, “I’m okay. It’s not bad flashbacks or anything. Just… a reminder,”

“Just think about all the people you’ve saved in this uniform. My gorgeous girl,”

“How’re you feeling?” Catra asked, tousling Adora’s blonde locks.

“Hey! Stop messing with my hair!” Adora insisted, grabbing Catra’s hands and kissing them. Catra blushed and sat next to Adora.

“You didn’t answer my question, baby,” Catra prodded gently, careful not to push Adora’s boundaries, but pointing out that avoidance wasn’t okay.

“I’m feeling a little scared,” Adora answered, eyes on the floor in a little bit of shame, “It’s just hard seeing you in uniform again. I want to be protective but It’s okay. I won’t be overbearing or anything. I’ll still be Adora-bearing though,” Adora joked, draping her arms on Catra’s shoulders. Catra chuckled softly.

“Alright, but just keep me updated on how you feel. It’s okay to struggle,” Catra whispered, leaning forward and pressing a chaste kiss on Adora’s lips, “I love you,”

“I love you too. Let’s head off, yeah?”

“Sounds good,” Catra agreed. As Catra drove, she left her tail curled up in Adora’s lap.

“Hey Catra?”

“Hm?”

“I’ve been thinking of switching jobs once you’re back at work,” Adora started, “I just… I think I want to enjoy my work more,” Adora started to pick at her cuticles, “I’m not sure but I wanna consider,”

“That sounds great,” Catra grinned, a fang peaking out. Adora let out a relieved exhale, “you don’t have to wait until I’m back at work though. I’m getting paid leave and we could… maybe move back in together?” Catra suggested, biting the inside of lip in excitement. Adora and Catra had still been living separately, not that it changed the fact that they spent most days together, “only if you’re ready.”

“I’m just worried,” Adora sighed. Catra deflated and nodded, “wait- that’s not a no-”

“It’s okay Adora,” Catra responded dismissively, but she was clearly a little hurt. But Catra would respect Adora’s decision-

“I'm only worried because when we lived together we didn’t make enough time for each other. It was like we never spent quality time together because we always saw each other. I don’t want to take our time together for granted, but I *do* want to live with you,” Adora explained. Catra hummed quietly, thinking.

“We could designate a date night, where we do something special? Maybe Wednesday to break up the week?” Catra proposed. Adora smiled.

“Yeah that’s a good idea,” Adora pet Catra’s tail on her thigh,

“Whose house do you think?”

“Honestly? I really like your apartment. It’s cozy, and there’s a spare room for…” Adora let her voice trail off.

“For *what*, Adora,” Catra grinned, knowing exactly where this was going.

"Y'know… *kids*," Adora coughed out, face red with blush as she bit the inside of her lip.

"You wanna have kids with me? How embarrassing for you," Catra teased. Adora groaned, "I wanna have kids with you too," Catra hummed. Adora went even more red- an impossible feat yet one Adora achieved, "But I'd want to settle in with our relationship, make sure everything is stable before we try,"

"Yeah, of course," Adora agreed, "and we're still 30. We've got time,"

"Mhm," Catra responded, "would you be okay with trying in a couple of years though?" Catra asked, somewhat nervously. Adora's eyes went wide.

"Definitely," Adora affirmed, "not until we settle in together though,"

"Agreed," Catra nodded.

The silence that lapsed between them was one of comfort, not so fragile as it had been when they were in the hospital. The month had been sewed plenty of conversations about their relationship, particularly with all the free time Catra had. It had them confronting issues they'd previously ignored, but they were more connected than they'd ever been and less excessively dependent on each other- prepared to face the music if it meant growing stronger.

When they arrived at Brightmoon's Castle, Catra clearly became alarmed. Her tail wrung around Adora's wrist as they walked through the main entrance, "Baby?" Adora questioned quietly, "what's up?"

"It's almost daunting, how big it is," Catra responded, unable to peel her eyes away from the giant building.

"*That's what she said*," Adora jested back, diffusing some of Catra's anxiety. Catra snorted and shoved her elbow into Adora's

waist.

“Of course you’d say something like that in a royal castle. Only you, Adora, know so little on decorum,” Catra teased, a playful lilt in her voice.

“Yeah yeah, get off your high horse, Miss-*elbows-on-the-table-during-dinner*,” Adora grinned, sneaking a kiss onto Catra’s neck. Catra laughed and pulled Adora into a proper kiss. But she kept it chaste, much to Adora’s annoyance.

“You can get more of that later. I’m not gonna make out with you in the hallway of Brightmoon Castle,” Catra grinned cheekily, tapping Adora’s forehead as she pulled away.

“I’m here all the time,”

“There’s no way Glimmer actually lives here,” Catra scoffed. Glimmer was still a sore topic, but Glimmer being Adora’s best friend meant that Catra would learn to deal with it.

“Hey! I do, for your info,” Glimmer scoffed from down the hallway. Catra and Adora’s heads turned towards her.

“Hey Glim!” Adora smiled, “which way is the ceremony?”

“Just through there,” Glimmer pointed down the corridor, “but um, Catra? Can I talk to you? If you don’t wanna then it's completely okay,” Glimmer looked just as nervous as Catra felt. She glanced over to Adora who shrugged.

“Today’s my first long day out of the house. I just wanna take it easy,” Catra declined politely, already feeling tired, “but maybe we could meet at a cafe tomorrow?”

“Yeah, that sounds good with me,” Glimmer responded, “anyways help yourself to the morning tea and food, there's a feast afterwards though so don’t fill up,” Glimmer teased, then walked away. Catra and Adora walked to the ceremony, where there was the morning tea Glimmer talked about.

“Catra?” Adora questioned gently. Catra had paused right before they entered the room to steady herself on one of the ornate hallway tables.

“I’m fine,” Catra dismissed in a strained tone. A tone that sounded not fine,

“Let’s find a place to sit-”

“Stop, I said I’m fine,” Catra responded harshly. Adora raised an eyebrow at Catra and Catra sighed, “that was uncalled for. Sorry,” She mumbled. Adora placed a hand on Catra’s back and rubbed.

“It’s okay. What can I do for you right now? Am I being too much?” Adora asked. Catra turned to hug Adora.

“No,” She mumbled into Adora’s hair, “I don’t want to take it easy anymore. I’m so sick of how breathless I get and I’m tired of resting. I just wanted one normal day out.”

“I know. It’s hard,” Adora said back, “you’ll get there eventually, but pushing yourself like this won’t work,” Adora rubbed Catra’s shoulder and kissed her neck. Catra frowned.

“M’kay. Let’s just find a couch,” She relented with embarrassment. Adora held Catra’s hand as they walked through the gala and-

Bumped into a bunch of Adora’s friends.

They all looked at Catra like they were *sorry* for her, as though they didn’t isolate her and avoid her like the plague when Adora and her had broken up, “Catra,” Mermista started. Catra had tried to rip their name from her head but clearly it bubbled back up. Catra was seething.

“What?” Catra scoffed. She had no reason to talk to these people. Adora looked very surprised at Catra’s harsh tone.

“Did I miss something?” Adora asked meekly to Catra. Catra didn’t respond, instead she glared at the group of people.

“We just wanted to say we're so sorry for what you’ve been through-” When Perfuma started talking, Catra cut her off swiftly.

“*No*, quite frankly you’re not. You just don’t wanna look bad,” Catra jeered, “now, if you don’t mind, I’m going anywhere else,” Catra scowled. Adora’s friends were yet another sore subject they were yet to fully talk about.

“I’ll come!” Adora assured, waving a quick goodbye to her friends and following Catra.

“Go be with your friends,” Catra dismissed, waving her hand as she found an exit.

“No, we said we’d stick together,” Adora insisted. Catra let out a frustrated sigh, pinching the bridge of her nose. Adora knew Catra was close to her breaking point. Her eyes were watering. Adora reached out and put a hand on Catra’s shoulder, “wanna take a breather?” Adora offered. Catra nodded, and Adora held Catra’s hand and led her down a little hallway. “What happened between you and our-... *my* friends?” Adora asked quietly as they walked. Catra rolled her eyes.

“Our breakup happened. They all isolated me,” Catra recalled bitterly, “even Scorpia,”

“*What*? But I thought you were living with her?”

“I moved out and she got distant,” Catra said, “it’s fine though,” Catra dismissed, “I’ve got friends who care about me now,”

“I can’t believe they’d do that to you,” Adora whispered in disbelief, feeling let down by her friends.

“They all wanted to pick a side or something,” Catra mumbled, “I guess they decided that you deserved the benefit of the doubt over me,” Catra’s voice was low and upset, knowing this whole situation was a glaring repeat of their childhood- Adora getting picked over Catra. It made Adora feel sick, and the fact that they

were in public and not the safety of their home where they were both comfortable amplified that feeling.

“That’s awful. I had no idea they did that to you,” Adora hugged Catra tightly. Catra sniffled, trying to tamper down her tears.

“It is what it is,” Catra shrugged, but she was clearly still hurt, “I just… I don’t want to hear their excuses. Bow's nice though, he reached out a bit to make sure I was okay, but I didn’t wanna talk to my ex-wife’s best friend, so I never responded with much. Still, it meant a lot to me,”

“That’s nice of him,” Adora said, “he’s always liked your company,” Adora complimented. Catra blushed- she wasn’t used to people liking her for who she was.

“Can we just relax for a bit? I’m feeling light headed,” Catra requested. She was embarrassed at having to admit it but she needed to do what was best for her.

“Yeah of course,” Adora affirmed, settling in on the couch, “it must be hard to see my friends after all that. I mean once upon a time they were *our* friends”

“It’s not hard seeing them,” Catra sighed, “it’s frustrating seeing the pity on their face, like they didn’t treat me like a stranger and isolate me.”

“I’d be mad too,” Adora admitted, “I, uh, I’m sorry,”

“You don’t have anything to be sorry for,” Catra responded, “I know you’re close with them, and that’s okay, but I don’t wanna hangout with them if all they’ll do is act like they’re sorry,”

“I don’t want to talk to them either. If they isolated you, then they aren’t the crowd I wanna be around. I have Bow and Glimmer,” Adora said.

“I don’t expect you to drop your friends for me,” Catra scoffed.

"I won't, but I don't think I'll be close with them," Adora amended, "I know the people I wanna be close with," Catra sniffled, "I think you should talk to Scorpia. She definitely didn't like me, so I can't imagine her picking my side or whatever,"

"She was dating Perfuma though," Catra reasoned. Adora tilted her head,

"They only started dating a month ago," Adora informed. Catra frowned, "they were friends around the time we broke up, but definitely not dating or even close,"

"I swear I saw them hanging out or… an instagram post. I dunno,"

"Just talk to Scorpia, I'm sure she has something to say," Adora suggested, shrugging confusedly. Catra nodded, then took a deep breath. Adora watched her carefully, looking for any signs of pain or hurt, before realising she was being overbearing and tried to focus on something else.

"I'm gonna find her then. I think she might be getting awarded too," Catra said, standing up slowly. Adora took a deep breath.

"I'm guessing you want to do this alone?" Adora asked, somewhat nervously because that meant leaving Catra alone.

"Yeah, but if you get really stressed you can find me," Catra assured, kissing Adora.

"Thanks, I'll go hang around Glim," Adora walked with Catra back to the main room when Catra spotted Scorpia. She approached and Scorpia's eyes widened.

"Oh gosh, Wildcat, it's been a minute," Scorpia rambled nervously.

"You hated Adora but you iced me out," Catra said, straight to the point. Scorpia flushed, "why?"

“Geez, this is embarrassing,” Scorpia mumbled, scratching the back of her head, “I know you did nothing to incite this, and that you were struggling and clearly not ready for a relationship, but I had feelings for you,” Scorpia admitted quietly, “I’m sorry, Catra,” It might be the first apology that Catra felt was genuine, “I know that it hurt you and I’m a bad friend for how I separated myself from you, but I just couldn’t be there for you… I needed space to get over you.” Catra let out a long exhale, running a hand through her hair.

“Okay,” Catra stared at the ground, “but if you ever wanna have another run at being friends, I missed you,” Catra shrugged.

“Gosh, I thought you’d never give me another chance,” Scorpia’s eyes watered as she pulled Catra in for a hug, “once I was past all of that, I thought too much time had passed and that I couldn’t reach out because you’d hate me-”

“Woah, slow your roll there,” Catra laughed dryly. She was about to continue when an event manager came up to them, and told them the award ceremony was to begin shortly.

Adora- Now

Adora stood in the wings of the stage, her medal already awarded and sitting on her chest. She was proud of herself, and nothing could take that away, but she also knew that it was time to move on from this career. She watched Catra walk onto the platform and they shared a brief smile as Angella read out a speech of gratitude for Catra’s contribution against the terrorist attack at the Mystacore Mall. Once it was over, Angella was passed the medal by an assistant, “WIthout further ado, It is my delight to award the Medal of Valor to Catra Weaver, Sergeant of the of the 99th Precinct in Brightmoon Police Department,” The whole crowd erupted into loud claps, cheering as Angella put the medal onto Catra. As Adora watched from the sidelines, she couldn’t help but cheer as well, despite instruction not to. A deep sense of pride swelled in her heart, and she couldn’t have been more proud of Catra. Adora was not a fool, she knew things were not perfect and

that they both had baggage from the past month, let alone the past years, but in that moment, she couldn’t have been happier.

Chapter End Notes

in another few months, ill write the meetup between catra and glimmer (maybe), so this isnt fully finished, but i thought this might be a nice place to leave it for now. there is reasoning behind glimmers actions, be that as it may you might still hate her lmao

also, just posted a new story called our cursed future, check it out if you're interested :)

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

small epilogue?

Adora- Now

Adora knew Catra was supposed to meet up with Glimmer the day after the award ceremony, but Catra ended up rescheduling it for the next week. Catra told Adora that she wanted to spend the time helping Adora pack up some of her things for the move, so they did. The week passed, yet Glimmer messaged Adora saying Catra canceled at the last minute. Glimmer hadn't been annoyed at all- on the contrary, she was genuinely worried about Catra. Adora was worried too, so she drove over to Catra's apartment and let herself in.

"Hey Catra," Adora said quietly as she entered their bedroom. Adora opened the blinds to let the light in then ran her hands her Catra's hair, gently brushing it out, "Glimmer said you cancelled, so I just wanted to make sure you were okay," The fact that Catra *wasn't okay* was obvious. She couldn't get out of bed, but not because she was physically unable to. Catra didn't respond to Adora's words, instead she curled up into a ball, "how's the pain today?"

"Not bad, I didn't sleep much though," Catra responded quietly. Adora was glad Catra spoke.

"You don't have to meet with her, you know? You don't owe this to anyone,"

"I know," Catra rasped. Adora scratched behind her ear, "I'm just not ready to hear how it's all my fault," Adora's affectionate movements stilled as she grimaced.

"But it isn't your fault," Adora assured. Catra's lips curled into an upset frown.

“Can we talk about this later? I’ll just meet up with Glimmer now and get it over and done with,” Catra moved sluggishly out of bed and Adora followed her nervously with her eyes, “please Adora, just not now,” Catra requested tiredly as she started to get changed.

“I’m worried,” Adora acknowledged. Catra stared at her dresser.

“I just need a little more time,” Catra pleaded, her voice bordering on desperate.

“Okay,” Adora whispered. Catra was clearly on the brink of crying, and Adora knew she needed to respect Catra’s boundaries, “I'm sorry,” Catra shrugged, and Adora knew Catra didn’t feel like she deserved the apology but Adora didn’t know how to get through to Catra. Still, Adora and Catra have learnt that they’re not always going to agree all the time. Her and Catra would work through this soon enough, just as they had every difficult topic that had arisen so far, “do you want me to call Glimmer?”

“Yeah if you can,” Catra affirmed. Adora stepped out of the room, ringing Glimmer. Once Glimmer had confirmed it was okay, Catra gave Adora a kiss and walked to the door, “wanna get some Mexican takeout for tonight?” Catra asked. Adora hummed, happy that their slight disagreement didn’t feel like the end of everything. Once upon a time, small discords ended in panic attacks. They knew how to handle conversations now.

“That sounds good, see you soon baby,” Adora smiled, taking another kiss from Catra. Catra took a deep breath and gave Adora a weak smile before walking out.

<u>Catra- Now</u>

Catra was zoned out the whole walk to her park. Granted, it was only a seven minute walk, but she still didn’t even realise she’d arrived until she was sitting on the bench and saw Glimmer approaching. Catra felt her throat tighten, realising that she was really here, and this was really happening, “Hi,” Glimmer said

quietly as she sat next to Catra on the bench, "thank you for meeting me. You didn't have to, so it really means a lot that you decided to," Catra shrugged indifferently and stayed silent for a few moments, trying to form her thoughts into the right words.

"Resentment isn't worth holding onto," Catra decided on saying, even though she knew she hadn't quite let go. She was working on it, and she knew that she didn't owe working on it to anyone either, but it was just to help herself feel better.

"You have a fair reason to resent me," Glimmer acknowledged, not out of pity for herself or for Catra, but as though to validate Catra's feelings. Catra shrugged once again- she seemed to be doing a lot of that lately, "I, uh, I know I really messed things up for you. Not just you, but also for Adora, and even our friends."

"Why'd you do it?" Catra asked. It was painfully to the point, but Catra had always been blunt and she wasn't going to waste her time beating around the bush with sentimentals and feelings.

"I was in a toxic relationship," Glimmer admitted, her eyes pinned to the swingset ahead of them, "I don't want you to take this in the wrong way, but my ex reminded me so much of you. You called me Sparkles when you answered the door and just… something in me switched. She used to do that to get on my nerves,"

"Your ex called you that?" Catra clarified. Glimmer nodded.

"We got into a fight the night before. Screamed at each other, and when you answered the door I could only think of her and I lashed out and took it out on you. She would villainise me all the time and I couldn't handle being the bad guy once more so when I realised how *shit* I had treated you, instead of trying to fix it I lied to Adora. I really fucking regret it all, but I don't think I deserve your forgiveness or anything like that," There was a slight pause, before Glimmer continued, "I thought you might want to know I've been working on myself since. I have more support and I make sure my friendships and relationships are productive. I

don’t want to hurt like that ever again, and I never wanna hurt someone the way I did to you and Adora. I’m sorry,” Glimmer let out an exhale, as did Catra as she processed everything said.

“Thank you for telling me all that,” Catra said, as a pleasantry more than anything, “You’re dating Bow now, right? Must be a massive switch up from a toxic girlfriend,” Glimmer let out a soft laugh.

“Definitely. We have so many conversations about how we’re feeling. When we argue we don’t even raise our voices. If I told that to my past self, I think she’d call me a pussy. But I’m happier now than I was then so I must be doing something right,” Glimmer smiled. Catra tried to think whether she was happier now. She felt like she was, but at the same time, she was still holding onto hate. It was wearing her down. She didn’t hate anyone else, though. She hated herself.

Adora- Now

Catra arrived back an hour after she left. Adora had stuck around in her apartment, too nervous to leave in case Catra came back even more upset. When Catra arrived home, Adora wrapped her in a big hug and brought her to the couch, “How’re you feeling?” Adora asked. She’d been hoping that Catra meeting up with Glimmer would help both of them feel better, but judging by the dim smile Catra gave Adora as a platitude, it hadn’t helped as much as she’d hoped.

“Facts are still facts,” Catra said, the smile slowly fading from her face as she leaned her head onto Adora’s shoulder. Adora placed a comforting hand on Catra’s thigh.

“What do you mean by that?” It was a question Adora regularly asked, not out of judgement but to avoid ambiguity. All she wanted was to understand Catra, and if that meant asking obvious questions, then she would ask them all.

“She was an asshole to the both of us, there’s no doubt, but she never made me leave you,” Catra muttered. Adora let out a sigh, half convinced that Catra would always blame herself for something that could never be her fault, “I was so angry at you when we separated, but I was the one who left-”

“I made you leave me,” Adora said, taking responsibility, “I didn’t listen to you. You tried to tell me that she was lying and I didn’t believe you. I gave you every reason to leave by not trusting you. It was wrong of me and I’m never gonna question your word like that again. *Unless* we’re playing Go Fish, then I’m gonna be questioning you a bunch because you’re *really* good at that childish game,”

“I’ll have you know Go Fish is for all ages,” Catra drawled jokingly.

“But seriously Catra, I’ll say it ‘til you understand me. I’m sorry for what I did to you. You didn’t cause it, and it wasn’t your fault,” Adora asserted. Catra’s eyes welled with tears and her heart clenched in her chest.

“I’m sorry,” Catra whispered.

“Don’t be,” Adora amended, “just go easy on yourself. You practically torment yourself over everything, when you didn’t do anything to end up alone like that. You got dealt a shitty hand, and you were trying to make do with what you had,”

“Dork,” Catra teased, pushing Adora’s shoulder lightly. She was clearly tired though, and Adora could tell Catra was emotionally exhausted. Adora kissed Catra softly, petting Catra’s side and cupping her jaw. Catra seemed surprised by the gentleness of it all, her eyes a little wider, “can you… do that again?” She asked nervously, shutting her eyes in anticipation of Adora saying no. But Adora *loved* it when Catra asked for affection. It made her more sure of what she was doing. She brought Catra in for another kiss and held her even closer, letting her hands roam across Catra’s shoulders then down her back to feel her muscles.

“My baby,” Adora whispered, pulling Catra closer and feeling *all* of her, “so gorgeous,” she said. Catra’s breathing got shaky. Adora rubbed her shoulders, before her hands trailed to the hem of Catra’s t-shirt, “forgive yourself, you didn’t do anything wrong,” Adora implored, “I’ll take care of you."

End Notes

wrote this late at night without looking over it oops sorry about mistakes

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